

Chapter 87 - Wild Trail

Whether it was the wind and snow or the thrilling sensation brought by the steep slopes of the advanced trail, it was incomparable to the intermediate trail.

The bitter cold wind mixed with flying snowflakes struck Feng Yue's goggles mercilessly, and even the strands of hair pressed down by her hat danced wildly in the wind.

Feng Yue's downward speed was getting faster and faster. Every time she passed a slope, the feeling of weightlessness in her heart stimulated her senses even more, making her almost unable to resist crying out loudly.

Yan Lin followed behind Feng Yue, but because the advanced trail had many slopes, she didn't dare follow too closely, fearing some collision accident.

Yan Lin watched Feng Yue's back figure skiing ahead, and it wasn't difficult to see Feng Yue's excitement at this moment.

The snow in the sky was falling heavier and heavier. They were about to reach the last turn of the trail, but Feng Yue, who was skiing ahead of Yan Lin, didn't turn left into the final bend. Instead, she turned right and skied into another trail, her figure disappearing from Yan Lin's sight.

Seeing this, Yan Lin's face changed dramatically. In her mind, she instantly recalled the entire trail distribution map of Tamanvi Ski Resort. If she remembered correctly, that trail was one of Tamanvi's undeveloped wild trails¹, densely forested and filled with scattered rocks.

Yan Lin couldn't care about anything else. She could only accelerate to catch up, trying to call out to stop Feng Yue.

But Feng Yue had no idea she had deviated from the track. She thought turning left or right was the same, since there were no signs at the end of the trail anyway.

Yan Lin's shouts couldn't compete with the howling wind and snow beside Feng Yue's ears. She just brazenly buried her head and skied forward for seven or eight minutes before gradually noticing that the scenery on both sides of the trail was becoming increasingly wrong.

The originally wide trail became narrower and narrower. The thick snow surface that had once been machine-groomed became increasingly soft, and there weren't even barriers on either side—only bushes with branches bent low by white snow.

Feng Yue became distracted observing the environment on both sides, and her speed gradually decreased. Yan Lin following behind finally had a chance to catch up with Feng Yue.

But a wild trail was still a wild trail. The obstacles and dangers it concealed far exceeded those of artificially developed trails.

When Feng Yue became distracted, she didn't pay attention to what was under her feet and suddenly hit a rock hidden in the soft white snow. Her whole body lunged forward, falling solidly into the snow, and even rolled several times forward due to inertia, causing her snowboard to detach and fall to the ground.

"A Yue!" Yan Lin was alarmed and accelerated desperately to reach Feng Yue's side.

Feng Yue was knocked dizzy by the fall, her whole body sinking into the snow. Because the soft snow cushioned her fall, she was fine elsewhere, but her right calf sent waves of sharp pain.

As soon as Yan Lin stopped, she took off her snowboard and knelt beside Feng Yue. "A Yue! A Yue! Are you okay? Can you still move?!"

Yan Lin didn't dare move her carelessly—the most common accident on ski slopes was bone fractures.

Feng Yue had rolled a few times and felt dizzy, but hearing Yan Lin's voice gave her some reassurance. She moved her arms and struggled to try to get up from the snow.

Seeing this, Yan Lin quickly supported her arms and pulled her up from the snow. During the process, she might have accidentally touched somewhere, causing Feng Yue to groan softly.

"Mmph—"

Yan Lin's face changed color with fright, and she didn't dare use force anymore, asking anxiously, "A Yue, are you hurt somewhere? Where does it hurt?"

"My leg... my leg seems to be injured." Whenever Feng Yue moved, she felt unbearable sharp pain from her right leg.

Yan Lin looked at her face, which had almost lost all color from pain, and had a bad feeling in her heart, but she couldn't scare Feng Yue anymore right now.

"It's okay, let's get out first so I can see where you're hurt."

Feng Yue nodded, then supported herself on Yan Lin's arm, enduring the pain from her calf, and sat down with difficulty on the snowboard Yan Lin had taken off.

The snow here was quite thick—stepping down, it could probably reach past Yan Lin's ankle.

She helped Feng Yue sit down, then placed her legs flat, took off her ski gloves, and crouched in front of Feng Yue. "Which foot is it?"

Feng Yue's forehead was already beaded with fine sweat from the pain. She swallowed and said, "Right... right foot."

Yan Lin nodded, then reached out to untie Feng Yue's ski boot, carefully removing the shoe and rolling up the outer ski pants. The ankle that had been covered by the ski boot was revealed to both of them, along with a bleeding wound that had stained the edge of Feng Yue's sock.

The bleeding wound wasn't within the protection range of the ski boot, but fortunately the wound wasn't long either—just the blood had stained Feng Yue's pant leg quite frighteningly.

Yan Lin gently touched Feng Yue's obviously swollen ankle. "Does it hurt more when I press on it?"

Feng Yue silently nodded.

"It should just be a sprain. The more troublesome thing is this wound." Saying this, Yan Lin gently lifted the blood-stained pants, finally seeing the wound clearly.

Feng Yue's wound was probably cut by rocks in the snow. With some protection from her ski pants and thermal underwear, the wound wasn't very large—about four or five centimeters.

Yan Lin took out a handkerchief from her bag, simply cleaned Feng Yue's wound and did some basic hemostasis², then put Feng Yue's shoe back on.

After doing all this, she finally exhaled a white puff and sighed in relief. Yan Lin took out her phone from her bag, wanting to call for help, but unfortunately there was no signal at all here.

Yan Lin turned around to see Feng Yue making the same motion. The two looked at each other and shook their heads simultaneously.

"Where is this? Isn't this the ski resort anymore?" Feng Yue's voice couldn't hide her self-reproach.

If she had agreed to take the snow vehicle with Jiang Ming, this wouldn't have happened. Now she and Yan Lin were stuck here in the middle of nowhere, and even their phones had no signal.

Yan Lin was also regretting it. If she had shown Feng Yue the trail distribution map before going on the advanced slope, Feng Yue definitely wouldn't have taken the wrong path.

"This is a wild trail closest to the ski resort, though based on this it can probably only be called a semi-wild trail. The advanced slope we were skiing connects to here. Usually, many skiers probably come here from the advanced slope seeking thrills." Saying this, Yan Lin paused. "Sorry, when I brought you to the advanced slope, I should have shown you the trail distribution map first."

"This isn't your fault either... I was the one who insisted on skiing down." Feng Yue looked at the increasingly heavy snow in the sky and the gradually darkening sky. "So what do we do now? Should we return the way we came?"

Yan Lin looked at Feng Yue's injured leg and shook her head. "We can't go up this slope on the wild trail. We can only walk downward now."

"But... it's getting dark." Feng Yue murmured.

Wild trails had no lights. If they were to go down the wild trail, they might very well lose their way in the darkness. Moreover, as the sky darkened, the outdoor temperature would also drop, and they might freeze to death in the snow.

Yan Lin looked at the seemingly endless trail and felt uncertain. If they didn't return for a long time, Jiang Zhao would definitely come looking for them. The trails all had surveillance, so it would be easy to discover they had taken the wrong path and come to this wild trail, and they would be rescued quickly.

But...

Yan Lin looked at the increasingly heavy snow and felt uneasy. In such heavy snow, the ski resort would definitely close, and staff wouldn't easily enter wild trails, since this kind of weather could easily trigger avalanches.

Once that happened, waiting in place would be waiting for death. Moreover, if Feng Yue's wound bled again, she might faint from excessive blood loss here, and once someone fainted in the wilderness...

Yan Lin didn't dare think further, but for a moment she didn't know how to choose.

Seeing her expression getting worse, Feng Yue also became increasingly uneasy. "What's wrong?"

Yan Lin pressed her lips together and told Feng Yue both options.

"When I entered the resort, I looked at the trail distribution map. This wild trail is the closest one to the ski resort, so many skiers have come here to ski. The resort probably built a small storage cabin in the middle of the wild trail for their safety, with food and water inside. If we can find this storage cabin, we can continue walking down after the snow stops."

After she finished speaking, both fell silent. They both understood that all of this was based on them being able to successfully find the storage cabin.

Once the two got lost in the wilderness, death would still await them.

After a long while, Feng Yue finally spoke: "Let's go. We can't just sit here and wait for death." Saying this, she picked up her ski pole from beside her, preparing to stand up.

Yan Lin reached out to support her, but pressed her back down onto the snowboard. "If we decide to walk down, you sitting on top while I pull you is the fastest method."

The increasingly heavy wind and snow and gradually darkening sky blocked the words Feng Yue wanted to use to object. Yan Lin was right—they needed to set off as soon as possible.

Feng Yue's right foot couldn't bend or move, so Yan Lin fixed Feng Yue's two snowboards to her own single board so Feng Yue's feet would have somewhere to rest. She herself held one ski pole while using her other hand to drag the front end of the snowboard, walking forward with deep and shallow steps.

The two walked in the wind and snow, shivering from cold, even the hair scattered outside seemed to freeze into ice.

Yan Lin could only watch ahead—she was afraid of stepping into a snow hole if she wasn't careful, so she walked very cautiously. But she was even more afraid that Feng Yue would lose her reason from the cold wind and snow, so she talked with Feng Yue from time to time.

The sky darkened, and the two walked on the steep snow trail. Their only light source was the flashlight on their phones, while the bushes on both sides of the trail were pitch black, as if hiding countless dangers.

Yan Lin carefully identified the direction, trying hard to walk toward the small storage cabin on the distribution map.

The two didn't know how long they had walked—so long that they no longer spoke and just silently moved forward. When Feng Yue was so frozen she could barely open her eyes, a small house hidden in the bushes finally appeared in her vision.

She struggled to open her eyes, wanting to identify whether she was seeing things. She looked several times and finally recognized that life-saving storage cabin.

But Yan Lin walking ahead seemed not to see any of this, just mechanically dragging the snowboard with Feng Yue forward.

Feng Yue moved her nearly frozen arms, grabbed the ski pole in her hands, and tapped the snowboard beneath her. Although her voice was weak, it had the power to instantly wake someone up.

"Yan Lin! We're here! We're here! Stop quickly!"

Yan Lin's figure suddenly halted, then she looked up to identify the direction before dragging Feng Yue toward that storage cabin.

Feng Yue looked at her stiffly walking back figure and had an ominous premonition in her heart.

Footnotes:

1. Wild trails (野道) - Undeveloped ski trails that are not maintained or patrolled by the resort, making them dangerous but popular among thrill-seekers
2. Hemostasis - The process of stopping bleeding, basic first aid for wounds